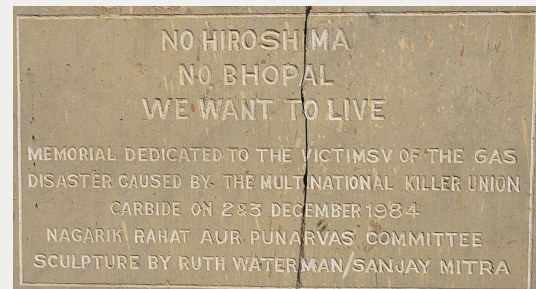


THE UNSUNG HEROES

There's a slogan within the rail community: "Once a railway person, always a railway person". This is truly reflected in the role that the railways played in saving countless lives during the Bhopal gas tragedy in 1984. Ex-Member (Staff), Railway Board, Manoj Pande, was Assistant Personnel Officer in Jhansi at the time and was deputed to help with the relief. He recounts how the general manager's inspection special on its way back to Bombay from Jhansi was detained at Sukhi Sewaian, a station short of Bhopal. Sensing the gravity of the situation, the general manager and a few other officers, went on the engine to the Bhopal railway station. They were met with chaos. The station was flooded with people, injured and in pain. Staff, officers, and medical personnel from the nearby towns of Bhusawal and Jhansi also reached there. A makeshift hospital was set up as well, as railway employees worked tirelessly in the hazardous situation. There was a huge exodus from the city, but railway services continued. Its employees stood firm, even though 45 colleagues, including Harish Dhurve, the station master, succumbed to the toxic gas.

Their courage is representative of the love most railway personnel feel for the system.



▲ A plaque commemorates the victims of the Bhopal gas tragedy.